

W H A L E C L A S S

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day

Landforms

Week 30

Week of Apr 19–23

13 minutes a day

ages 2.5–6

English learners





Week 30 · Week Overview

Landforms
Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

5 words they'll own by Friday →

mountain

river

island

lake

land

🌍 Water on the mat from Tuesday on — put the towel down before the children sit down. Grain Rain falls on Tuesday 20 April and Earth Day on Thursday 22 April: one nod each, then straight back to the landforms.

Littles (2.5–3)

One word + a gesture is a win: **“Mountain!”** (both hands make a peak over your head), **“River!”** (one arm winds along in front of you), **“Island!”** (one fist is the land, the other hand circles round it).

Bigs (4–6)

Sentence frames: **“This is a mountain.”**

“The river is long.”

“An island has water all around.”

“The lake is still.”

The week at a glance

MON	Up the Mountain	a real rock in the Magic Box
TUE	Down the River	a jug of water and a tilted tray in the Magic Box (a metal baking tray propped up at one end o...
WED	Round the Island	a clay island sitting in a basin of water, and a paper boat, in the Magic Box
THU	Still as a Lake	a lake in the Magic Box
FRI	Land & Water + Big Review	the island & lake land-form model (or this week's two clay ones side by side) and a jug of blu...

2 MIN

📦 Magic Box hook



4 MIN

📢 Teach the words



3 MIN

🎵 Song · today's verse



3 MIN

⚡ Game · move it



1 MIN

🗯️ Whisper-shout close

Weekly rituals — use these every single day

Attention grabber: Teacher: **“One, two, three — eyes on me!”** · Kids: **“One, two — eyes on you!”**

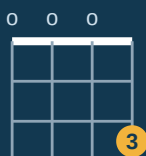
The Magic Box: any box with a lid. Chant it, shake it, sniff it, peek dramatically — the day's key prop lives inside.

The two-tier rule: never make a little produce a sentence, and never let a big get away with one word.

Whisper → shout close: calms them down, then releases them — every single closing.

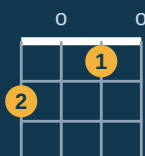
Teacher-fails-on-purpose: once a day, get it wrong and let them correct you — the correction shout is the loudest language of the day.

One song a week: same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole song on Friday.



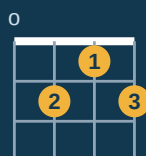
GCEA

C



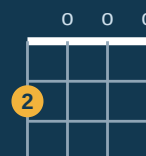
GCEA

F



GCEA

G7



GCEA

Am

Uke quick-ref

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“climb — climb — climb-ing”). Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the mountain going up.

The song needs only **C · F · G7 · Am**.

MONDAY

Up the Mountain

Today's words: **mountain**

Grab: a **real rock** in the Magic Box — a heavy one, so the box is heavy; a tray of **wet sand** on the mat with a small jug of water and a spray bottle; the picture cards from print pack page 11; the **mountain** card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box is **heavy**. Lift it with two hands, let it sag, and pretend it is nearly going to drop.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — one deep **thud**, not a rattle. Sniff it: nothing at all. Peek in for a long moment and let your eyebrows go right up.

TEACHER "Something in here is **HARD**... and it is very, very **OLD**." (*lift the rock out in both hands, slowly, as if it weighed as much as you do*)

The rock goes right round the circle and every child holds it in two hands. Peak hands over heads: "**Mountain!**"

4 MIN TEACH · MOUNTAIN

Everybody stands up. We **are** the mountain, twice — tiny first, then enormous:

My mountain is **small**. (*crouch right down, hands in a tiny peak*)

My mountain is **TALL**. (*grow up onto tiptoe, hands in a big peak*)

Up... up... up we climb... (*climbing hands, higher and higher*)

and I am **very small!** (*arms wide at the top, then shrink right down*)

Then the wet sand. Pile it up with both hands, pat it firm, spray it once so it holds, and let one child set the **rock** on the very top — that is the peak. It stays on the shelf all week and it will still be there on Friday.

LITTLES do the peak hands and say "**Mountain!**" **BIGS** take the frame: "**This is a mountain.**" "**The mountain is tall.**"

Teacher fails: build your mountain **upside down** — dig a deep hole in the sand, step back and admire it. "There. A beautiful mountain." Hold it. Wait.

Chinese moment: lay the **mountain** card at the foot of the sand tray. *mountain is a mountain* — three peaks, one tall one in the middle. Draw it in the wet sand with one finger. Leave the card there; the row grows by one card a day.

3 MIN GAME · BE A MOUNTAIN

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everybody in a space of their own, standing.

TEACHER "**BIG** mountain!" (*everybody grows onto tiptoe, hands in a huge peak*) ... "**little** mountain!" (*everybody shrinks to a tiny crouching peak*)

Faster and faster, and get it wrong yourself once or twice. Then the good part: **two children make one mountain together**, back to back with their hands meeting in a point above them. Then three. Then the whole class, in one enormous mountain range across the room, tall ones and small ones side by side.

End it standing still: "A mountain does not move." Ten seconds of a completely frozen room is worth having, and they will hold it because they are being a mountain, not being told to sit.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody standing, peak hands ready. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Up the mountain... down the RIVER!" (*climbing hands going up on the first half · swimming arms going low on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Mountain Dance* (Thomas Locker) — big quiet paintings of mountains and about four words a page. Read it slowly and let them just look.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · UP THE MOUNTAIN, DOWN THE RIVER chorus → Monday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Up the mountain — **F** climb, climb, **C** climb! (*climbing hands, higher and higher*)

Am Down the **C** river — **G7** swim in **C** time! (*swimming arms, low*)

C Round the **F** island, round the **C** lake, (*draw two circles in the air*)

Am What a **C** lovely **G7** world we **C** make! (*arms thrown wide*)

MONDAY · MOUNTAIN

C A mountain is high, a mountain is tall, (*peak hands, small then big*)

G7 Up at the top **C** I am very small! (*reach up, then shrink right down*)

The one song of the week — same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole thing on Friday. Chords and the full sheet are on the Song tab. Sing it standing, with the sand mountain in the middle of the circle.

TUESDAY

Down the River

Today's words: **river** (*mountain comes back every day*)

Grab: a **jug of water** and a **tilted tray** in the Magic Box (a metal baking tray propped up at one end on a book); a long blue ribbon; six little cups and two bowls for the relay; a **towel down first**; the **river** card. **Grain Rain** is today.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box **sloshes**. Carry it carefully. Chant, then tip it a few centimetres from side to side and let them hear it.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Hold a finger to your lips and listen to it with your ear right against the lid.

TEACHER "Careful... something in here is going to **RUN AWAY**." (*lift out the jug, then the tray, and set the tray down propped up at one end*)

One arm winds along in front of them: **"River!"**

4 MIN TEACH · RIVER

The tray is propped so one end is high — that end is yesterday's mountain. Pour, very slowly, right at the top, and say nothing at all while the water finds its way down.

Everybody follows it with one finger in the air and we all say it together, long and low: **"Riverrrrr."** Then the words, twice:

A river **runs**, (*one arm winds along*)

it never stops, (*keep it winding, don't let the arm rest*)

Down the **hill**... (*the arm slopes downhill*)

it **drips and drops!** (*fingers raining down onto the floor*)

Now take the book away and pour onto the **flat** tray. Nothing runs; it just sits there in a puddle. Ask them why, and wait for it: **a river needs a hill**. Prop it up again and let a child do the pouring.

LITTLES do the winding arm and say **"River!"** **BIGS** owe you the sentence: **"The river is long."** **"The water runs down."**

Teacher fails: try to pour the water **up** the tray, from the low end, and get crosser and crosser with it. "It will not go up. What is *wrong* with this river?" Wait.

Chinese moment: the **river** card joins mountain. Today is Grain Rain, the last solar term of spring: **the rain that grows a hundred grains**, the rain that makes a hundred grains grow. Say it once, then one line of Du Fu's "Welcome Rain on a Spring Night": **Good rain knows its season; it comes when spring arrives**. One line only, then stop.

3 MIN GAME · PASS THE RIVER

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" One long line, sitting, with a **full bowl** at one end and an **empty bowl** at the other. Put a strip of tape on the empty bowl to mark how high we want to get.

TEACHER "Fill your little cup... pass it on... the river goes **this way!**" (*the cup travels hand to hand down the line and is tipped into the far bowl*)

Everybody gets a cup, so the water is always moving. Spilling is completely fine and it is meant to be funny — that is why the towel is down. At the end, hold the far bowl up and see how close to the tape the river got. **LITTLES** say **"River!"** as they pass; **BIGS** say **"The water runs down the line."**

Run it twice: once fast and sloppy, once slow and careful. They will notice all by themselves which one filled the bowl higher, and that is the whole lesson in carrying water.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody standing, one arm winding. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Up the mountain... down the **RIVER!**" (*climbing hands going up on the first half · swimming arms going low on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *A River* (Marc Martin) — one river seen from a window and followed all the way to the sea. Trace it with a finger on every page.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · UP THE MOUNTAIN, DOWN THE RIVER chorus → Tuesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Up the mountain — **F** climb, climb, **C** climb! (*climbing hands, higher and higher*)

Am Down the **C** river — **G7** swim in **C** time! (*swimming arms, low*)

C Round the **F** island, round the **C** lake, (*draw two circles in the air*)

Am What a **C** lovely **G7** world we **C** make! (*arms thrown wide*)

TUESDAY · RIVER

C A river runs and never stops, (*winding arm, travelling downhill*)

G7 Down the hill **C** it drips and drops! (*fingers raining down to the floor*)

Sing this one *travelling*: start the verse standing tall with your hands up at the mountain and finish it crouched on the floor with your fingers pattering. The song does the geography for you.

WEDNESDAY

Round the Island

Today's words: **island** (*mountain · river come back*)

Grab: a **clay island** sitting in a basin of water, and a **paper boat**, in the Magic Box — the box is carried **flat**; a hoop or a length of rope for the game; paper for more boats; the towel; the **island** card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box cannot be shaken at all, and that is the hook. Carry it in flat on two hands like a birthday cake.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Start to shake it — tip it about a millimetre — then gasp and hold it dead still.

TEACHER "I **can't** shake it today. If I shake this box... the whole **sea** comes out." (*lift the lid and turn it round the circle so everybody sees the water before anything is lifted out*)

Set the basin down in the middle. One fist is the land, the other hand circles it: **"Island!"**

4 MIN TEACH · ISLAND

The basin stays in the middle of the circle where everyone can see the water. Say it twice; the second time they do the hands with you:

An **island** sits in the sea, (*one fist held out in front of you*)
with water all **around**, (*the other hand circles round and round the fist*)
Hop in my boat and off we go — (*rowing arms*)
right the way round! (*one big circle in the air*)

Then the boat. Float it and push it gently all the way round the clay island without ever touching the land. Every child gets one push, and the class counts the laps.

Say the definition once, slowly, with the fist and the circling hand: **an island is land with water all round it.**

LITTLES do the two hands and say **"Island!"** **BIGS** owe you the sentence: **"An island has water all around."** **"My boat goes round the island."**

Teacher fails: lift the clay island out of the water and set it on the dry table. "There. My island." Admire it. Wait for somebody to point at the empty basin.

Chinese moment: the **island** card joins mountain · river. Show them what is hiding in it: a **bird** sitting on top of a **mountain** that pokes up out of the sea. Once they have seen the bird on the mountain they never forget the character.

3 MIN GAME · SAIL ROUND THE ISLAND

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" A hoop or a rope circle on the floor is the island. Everybody else is a boat.

TEACHER "Boats... **sail!**" (*everybody walks round the island, rowing*) ... "Boats... **STOP!**" (*freeze — and nobody may be touching the island*)

Then turn round and sail the other way. Then a storm: big waves, wobbly walking, and STOP. The one rule all the way through is that the island is land and boats do not go on the land.

Last round, put two children **on** the island and let them wave at the boats going past. **LITTLES** just walk and row; **BIGS** call out **"I can sail round the island!"** as they go.

If the room is small, make the island out of one child standing still with their arms folded. A landform you can look in the eye is better than a hoop.

1 MIN CLOSE

Standing round the basin, boats parked. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Up the mountain... down the **RIVER!**" (*climbing hands going up on the first half · swimming arms going low on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Little Island* (Golden MacDonald & Leonard Weisgard) — one small island through a whole year. It is old and quiet and they go completely still for it.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · UP THE MOUNTAIN, DOWN THE RIVER** chorus → Wednesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Up the mountain — **F** climb, climb, **C** climb! (*climbing hands, higher and higher*)

Am Down the **C** river — **G7** swim in **C** time! (*swimming arms, low*)

C Round the **F** island, round the **C** lake, (*draw two circles in the air*)

Am What a **C** lovely **G7** world we **C** make! (*arms thrown wide*)

WEDNESDAY · ISLAND

C An island is land with water all round, (*fist, other hand circling it*)

G7 Hop in my boat — **C** look what I found! (*rowing, then hands out in surprise*)

Sing the verse sitting in a ring round the basin with the boat actually floating. The song is three minutes; the boat going round is the metronome.

THURSDAY

Still as a Lake

Today's words: **lake** (mountain · river · island come back)

Grab: a **lake** in the Magic Box — a mound of clay or plasticine with a hollow scooped out of the top, plus a jug of blue water to fill it; a small **mirror**; one cup of water per child for the game; yesterday's island basin; the towel; the **lake** card. **Earth Day** is today.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today there are two things in the box and one of them looks like nothing at all.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Lift out the clay mound with the hollow in the top and hold it up. Turn it round. Look disappointed.

TEACHER "It's a **hole**. That's all it is. A hole in the land." (now lift out the jug and fill the hollow right to the brim, slowly) "...and **now** it's a **LAKE**."

Cupped hands held out in front, water sitting in them: "**Lake!**"

4 MIN TEACH · LAKE

Put yesterday's island basin down beside today's lake and do the two of them one after the other, with the hands, twice:

An **island** — land with water all round. (fist, and the other hand circling it)

A **lake** — water with **land** all round. (cupped hands, one finger circling inside them)

Still and quiet... (finger on your lips)

not a sound. (whisper it, hands completely still)

Then the mirror, laid flat on the mat: **a still lake is a mirror**. Hold the mountain card upside down above it and let them see the mountain standing in the water. Breathe on the water in the clay lake and the picture wobbles away.

LITTLES do the cupped hands and say "**Lake!**" **BIGS** owe you the sentence: "**The lake is still.**" "**A lake has land all around.**"

Teacher fails: swap them over. Hold up the island in its basin and announce, very confidently, "and **this** one is a lake." Nod. Wait for the roar.

Chinese moment: the **lake** card joins mountain · river · island. Point at the three little strokes on the left of both **river** and **lake** — that is water, and it is hiding in every water word. Then **Earth Day**, in one sentence: every mountain, river, island and lake we have made this week is on **one round Earth**, and it belongs to all of us to look after. Then straight back to the lake.

3 MIN GAME · DON'T WAKE THE LAKE

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Every child gets a cup filled right up to the top. The class sits in a ring and the room goes silent.

TEACHER "Your cup is a **lake**. A lake is **still**. Walk it all the way round... and don't wake it." (one child at a time walks the circle while everybody watches the water, not the child)

They will walk more slowly and more carefully than you have ever seen them walk. Anybody who spills just fills it up again and goes once more. **LITTLES** carry a half-full cup a quarter of the way; **BIGS** go the whole way round and tell you "**My lake is still.**"

This is a practical-life exercise dressed up as a game — carrying water is a real Montessori skill and this is the day it gets a name. Tray 3 keeps it available all week.

1 MIN CLOSE

Standing round the clay lake, cupped hands ready. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Up the mountain... down the **RIVER!**" (climbing hands going up on the first half · swimming arms going low on the shout)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Over and Under the Pond* (Kate Messner & Christopher Silas Neal) — everything living above and below still water. Perfect on lake day.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · UP THE MOUNTAIN, DOWN THE RIVER chorus → Thursday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Up the mountain — **F** climb, climb, **C** climb! (climbing hands, higher and higher)

Am Down the **C** river — **G7** swim in **C** time! (swimming arms, low)

C Round the **F** island, round the **C** lake, (draw two circles in the air)

Am What a **C** lovely **G7** world we **C** make! (arms thrown wide)

THURSDAY · LAKE

C A lake is water with land all round, (cupped hands, finger circling inside)

G7 Still and quiet — **C** not a sound! (finger on lips, everything still)

Finish the verse on a whisper and hold the silence for three whole seconds before the chorus crashes back in. The contrast is the whole trick, and they will ask for it again.

FRIDAY

Land & Water + Big Review

Today's words: **land** — and **mountain · river · island · lake**, the whole week

Grab: the **island & lake land-form model** (or this week's two clay ones side by side) and a jug of blue water; every prop from the week packed into the box, plus a handful of plain **earth**; the sorting cards and the two signs (print pack pages 12–14); the awards (page 17); the **earth** card; shoes on — we go outside.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box comes out bulging and will not quite shut.

TEACHER "Today the box is **FULL** — it's got our whole **WEEK** inside it!"

Pull each thing out and hold it up in complete silence. They will supply the word before you can.

The rock → "**Mountain!**" The jug and the tilted tray → "**River!**" The clay island in its water → "**Island!**" The clay lake → "**Lake!**"

Last of all, one thing left in the bottom: a handful of plain **earth**. Let it run through your fingers. "**LAND!**"

4 MIN TEACH · LAND, THEN THE WHOLE WEEK

Everybody stands. We tell the whole week with our bodies, twice — slow, then fast:

Mountain, (*peak hands over your head*) **river**, (*one arm winds along*)

island, (*fist, other hand circling*) **lake**, (*cupped hands, still*)

Land and water — (*one hand flat and steady, one hand wavy*)

that's what we **make!** (*arms thrown wide*)

Then the land-form model, and this is the moment of the week: pour the blue water into both trays and say the pair out loud, twice, pointing. **Island: land with water all round it. Lake: water with land all round it.** Same two things, swapped over.

Then the big sort, right there on the mat: every card from page 14 goes under **Land** or **Water**. The class decides together and nobody is told the answer.

LITTLES do the five gestures and shout the five words. **BIGS** owe you a whole sentence each: "**An island has water all around.**" "**A lake has land all around.**" "**The mountain is tall.**"

Teacher fails: pour the blue water carefully onto the **floor** beside the model, put the jug down and dust off your hands. "Done." Wait.

Chinese moment: the **earth** card joins the row — mountain · river · island · lake · earth, the whole week laid out on the mat. **the land** is the great wide land, and **Earth** is the Earth: the same earth. Read the five characters right along the row, all together, once, loudly.

3 MIN GAME · LANDFORM QUICK-FIRE, THEN OUTSIDE

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" First the quick-fire, indoors: hold up a card, they shout the word and do the gesture, and you go faster and faster until it falls apart laughing. Mix in the two signs — land or water?

TEACHER "Shoes on! We are going to find a **mountain**, a **river**, an **island** and a **lake**... **outside.**"

In the sandpit and at the water table: build the mountain, dig the river, make the island in the tray, scoop the hollow and fill it for the lake. Anything they cannot find, they **make**. **LITTLES** name each one as it appears; **BIGS** tell a friend what they built and how: "**I made an island. It has water all around.**"

Take four photographs out there — one per landform — and print them for Tray 4 on Monday. The photo of their own sandpit mountain beside the photo of a real one is the best matching material in the room, and it costs nothing.

1 MIN CLOSE + AWARDS

Every child gets a "You are a STAR!" award to take home with their landform photo. Then, standing round the model, all five gestures:

EVERYONE "Up the mountain... down the RIVER!" (*climbing hands going up on the first half · swimming arms going low, and everybody's arms thrown wide on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? Follow the Water from Brook to Ocean (Arthur Dorros) — the river from a trickle to the sea, which is exactly the week, and it hands you Monday's Earth Day theme on a plate.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · UP THE MOUNTAIN, DOWN THE RIVER** Friday's verse, then the **WHOLE** song, top to bottom

CHORUS

C Up the mountain — **F** climb, climb, **C** climb! (*climbing hands, higher and higher*)

Am Down the **C** river — **G7** swim in **C** time! (*swimming arms, low*)

C Round the **F** island, round the **C** lake, (*draw two circles in the air*)

Am What a **C** lovely **G7** world we **C** make! (*arms thrown wide*)

FRIDAY · LAND AND WATER

C Mountain, river, island, lake, (*all four gestures in a row*)

G7 Land and water — **C** that's what we make! (*flat hand · wavy hand · arms wide*)

The finale: chorus → Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday → chorus, standing in a ring round the land-form model with the whole week's props laid out in front of them. They learned it one verse a morning without ever noticing, and this run-through **is** the review of the whole week.

★ Up the Mountain, Down the River

Week 30 theme song
C (0003) · F (2010) · G7 (0212) · Am (2000)

The one song of the week — sung at every circle. Same chorus daily, one new verse each morning, full song on Friday.

CHORUS — SING IT EVERY SINGLE DAY

- C** Up the mountain — **F** climb, climb, **C** climb! (*climbing hands, higher and higher*)
Am Down the **C** river — **G7** swim in **C** time! (*swimming arms, low*)
C Round the **F** island, round the **C** lake, (*draw two circles in the air*)
Am What a **C** lovely **G7** world we **C** make! (*arms thrown wide*)

MONDAY · MOUNTAIN

- C** A mountain is high, a mountain is tall, (*peak hands, small then big*)
G7 Up at the top **C** I am very small! (*reach up, then shrink right down*)

TUESDAY · RIVER

- C** A river runs and never stops, (*winding arm, travelling downhill*)
G7 Down the hill **C** it drips and drops! (*fingers raining down to the floor*)

WEDNESDAY · ISLAND

- C** An island is land with water all round, (*fist, other hand circling it*)
G7 Hop in my boat — **C** look what I found! (*rowing, then hands out in surprise*)

THURSDAY · LAKE

- C** A lake is water with land all round, (*cupped hands, finger circling inside*)
G7 Still and quiet — **C** not a sound! (*finger on lips, everything still*)

FRIDAY · LAND AND WATER

- C** Mountain, river, island, lake, (*all four gestures in a row*)
G7 Land and water — **C** that's what we make! (*flat hand · wavy hand · arms wide*)

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“climb — climb — climb-ing”).

Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the mountain going up. Practice this loop for five minutes tonight: **C** (4 strums) → **F** (4 strums) → **C** → **Am** → **C** → **G7** → **C**. That is the entire chorus. **C** is one finger, **Am** is one finger, **F** is two, **G7** is three; learn them in that order, and note that every one of the five verses is only **C** and **G7** — so if the chorus defeats you on Monday, play the verses and sing the chorus unaccompanied. If your fingers get stuck altogether, put the uke down, put the sand tray in the middle and do the finger-play instead: the class will not notice, and the actions carry the meaning either way.